



Glossary

Abruption Premature separation of the placenta from the wall of the uterus.

Active positions An approach to childbirth that involves upright positions and movements during labor.

Active labor The point during labor in which the cervix begins to dilate more rapidly and contractions are stronger, last longer, and are closer together.

Alveoli Milk glands in the breasts, which produce a flow of milk when they are stimulated by prolactin and the baby's sucking.

Amniocentesis The surgical extraction of a small amount of amniotic fluid through the pregnant woman's abdomen. This procedure is usually performed as a test for fetal abnormalities.

Amnion The thin inner membrane surrounding the fetus and the amniotic fluid. It's also known as the amniotic sac.

Amniotic fluid The fluid that surrounds the fetus in the uterus. Ultrasounds may be done in late pregnancy to ensure that enough fluid is present.

Amniotomy The surgical rupture of the amniotic sac, often done to speed up labor. This is referred to as ARM (artificial rupture of the membranes).

Anemia A condition in which there is an abnormally low percentage of hemoglobin in the red blood cells. It is treated by taking iron supplements.

Anesthetic Medication that produces partial or complete insensibility to pain.

Anesthesia, general Anesthetic that affects the whole body, with temporary loss of consciousness.

Antibiotics Substances capable of destroying or limiting the growth of microorganisms, especially bacteria.

Antibodies Protein produced naturally by the body to combat any foreign bodies, germs, or bacteria.

Apgar score A general test of the baby's well-being performed at 1, 5, and 10 minutes after the birth to assess the baby's heart rate and tone, respiration, blood circulation, and nerve responses.

Areola The pigmented circle of skin surrounding the nipple.

Bilirubin Broken-down hemoglobin, normally converted to nontoxic substances by the liver. Some newborn babies have levels of bilirubin too high for their livers to deal with (neonatal jaundice).

Blastocyst An early stage of the developing egg after fertilization, when it has divided and subdivided into a group of cells.

Bloody show A vaginal discharge of bloodstained mucus occurring before labor, resulting from the onset of cervical dilatation. A sign that labor is starting.

Braxton-Hicks contractions Practice contractions of the uterus that occur throughout pregnancy, but which may not be noticed until toward the end of pregnancy.

Breast pump A device for drawing milk from the breasts.

Breech presentation When the position of the baby in the uterus is bottom down rather than head down.

Carpal tunnel syndrome Numbness and tingling of the hands arising from pressure on the nerves of the wrist. In pregnancy, it is caused by the body's accumulation of fluids.

Cephalic presentation The position of a baby who is head down in the uterus. The most common presentation.

Cephalopelvic disproportion A state in which the head of the fetus is larger than the cavity of the mother's pelvis. Delivery of the baby must therefore be by C-section.

Cervical dilation See *Dilation*.

Cervical insufficiency A disorder of the cervix, usually arising after a previous midpregnancy termination or damage to the cervix during a previous labor, in which the cervix opened up too soon, resulting in repeated midpregnancy miscarriages. It is sometimes treated by stitching to hold the cervix closed during pregnancy.

Cervix The lower entrance to the uterus, or neck of the uterus.

Cesarean section (C-section) The delivery of the baby through an incision in the abdominal and uterine walls.

Chorion The outer membrane tissue that envelops the fetus and placenta.

Chloasma Pigmentation of the skin that causes darker patches, often on the face. Also known as melasma.

Chorionic gonadotrophin See *Human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG)*.

Chorionic villus sampling A method of screening for genetic disease by analyzing tissue from the small protrusions on the outer membrane enveloping the embryo (chorion), which later forms the placenta.

Chromosomes Rodlike structures containing genes. They occur in pairs within the nucleus of every cell. Human cells each contain 23 pairs.

Cleft palate A congenital abnormality of the roof of the mouth and upper lip. It is often treated with reconstruction surgery.

Colostrum A kind of milk, rich in proteins, formed and secreted by the breasts in late pregnancy and gradually changing to mature milk some days after the birth.